

Five Steps to Financial Wellbeing

we talk about things, and learn to understand them, the more healthily we can process them. All of this applies as much to money, and our relationship with it, as to anything else. If we can break the chokehold that money often keeps us in, we can start to gain control over both the practical and the emotional side of our finances.

Feeling frozen in shame about financial mistakes that we have made, or knowledge and understanding that we lack, or a lack of financial privilege in our background, is often the thing that holds us back from seeking the information and support that we need. Money is one area where it is still not widely acceptable to be seen as vulnerable, so we build our walls high and dig our trenches deep, and we pretend that everything is fine, even when it's not. Because of this, sometimes even those people with significant financial privilege, in the form of wealthy (or even comfortably off) parents or access to good financial advice, will insist on struggling on alone, preferring the stress and anxiety to opening up or asking for help. As fortunate as it is to be in a position whereby you *could* ask for and receive financial help, the theoretical ability to seek support does not serve much of a purpose if financial shame and anxiety make it impossible to actually do so.

As well as the ability to access material help when needed, another thing that openness about money affords us is catharsis. Until I started spilling my darkest financial secrets to thousands of strangers, I was genuinely in the dark about how many other people struggled to manage their money, or had a com-